1.3.1. C

The C programming language is one of the most widely used, and enduring, general-purpose programming languages of all time. JavaScript *deliberately* looks like the C programming language with many syntactical similarities. One of the most obvious similarities is the use of curly braces, `{` and `}`, to indicate the beginning and end of each block of code. JavaScript is not alone in sharing this syntax with C—many mainstream programming languages look like C. Why should it matter that JavaScript borrows syntax from C? It matters because the story of a programming language (like the story of any language) is, in many regards, a social one. Here's one account of that story.

Anybody who studied computer science when grunge music was popular knew that all the cool kids were using C with curly braces and that C programming was *real* programming, involving things like managing memory and manipulating strings as arrays of char pointers. The C programming language was the most grown-up thing to write besides assembly language, and the computer science departments in universities around the world were full of youth. Finally, and perhaps most importantly, most computer games at the time were written in C, and all those young people wanted to write computer games.

The schools of computer science were motivated to produce graduates who could get jobs, so the three most popular languages at the time were often taught. All three of these languages—C, C++, and Java—have curly braces. There were many less-popular languages with different styles, syntax, semantics, and ideas, but things found in unpopular places are easily ignored—regardless of whether they're good or bad. That's why JavaScript looks like the C programming language.

Despite being dressed in a curly-brace suit and semicolon top hat to look like C, JavaScript took two core ideas from other languages called Scheme and Self. As it happens, neither Scheme nor Self was quite so popular or looked very much like C, C++, or Java. So, although JavaScript looks very much like C, some of the core ideas are very much unlike C. To understand